

Speaker 1 [00:00:01] First of all, thank you again for participating in this interview. As I mentioned in the message we sent, we are curious about your views on romantic relationships and would like to learn more. We believe that your experiences and perspective will greatly contribute to this project. According to the informed consent form I sent you yesterday, do you agree to participate in this study?

Speaker 2 [00:00:28] Your voice just cut off.

Speaker 1 [00:00:37] Yes, what was the last thing you heard from me?

Speaker 2 [00:00:42] I remember you mentioning the consent form.

Speaker 1 [00:00:45] Yes. Do you agree to participate in this study according to the informed consent form I sent yesterday?

Speaker 2 [00:00:51] I agree.

Speaker 1 [00:00:53] Alright. First, I will ask you a few demographic questions. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:58] By the way, if my connection drops, you can text me on [Social Media]. The internet is a bit problematic where I am. I am [20-25] years old.

Speaker 1 [00:01:08] Okay. How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:01:12] Since [Month]. I need to count, one minute. [6-10] months.

Speaker 1 [00:01:22] [6-10] months. Do you have any children?

Speaker 2 [00:01:25] No.

Speaker 1 [00:01:27] Who do you live with at home?

Speaker 2 [00:01:30] I live with my [name] and [name] at home.

Speaker 1 [00:01:32] Alright. What is your main source of income?

Speaker 2 [00:01:36] I'm a [occupation]. My main source of income is [source of income].

Speaker 1 [00:01:39] Okay. How would you like me to refer to your partner? Spouse, sevgili, partner?

Speaker 2 [00:01:45] Partner is suitable for me.

Speaker 1 [00:01:47] Alright. Now I will ask some questions in a more romantic context. Can you tell me the story of how you met your partner and how your relationship started?

[Portion Redacted]

Speaker 1 [00:02:58] Okay. How would you compare the quality of your relationship to the relationships of your friends?

Speaker 2 [00:03:07] I think, in many ways, considering what we mean by quality, I need to think about what quality means in a relationship first.

Speaker 1 [00:03:17] Uh-huh.

Speaker 2 [00:03:18] Due to its dynamics, it is already in a non-traditional structure. Therefore, I think this non-traditional structure creates fewer cliché problems, less of what we call toxic situations, and thus allows people to feel more at peace and be more honest.

Speaker 1 [00:03:42] Uh-huh, can you elaborate on what you mean by less toxic and cliché? Why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:03:48] Sure. For example, the people around me are generally monogamous, almost all of them. In their relationships, I often see things like possessiveness, conservatism, not respecting each other's decisions in life, and interfering with what the other does. For example, these are things very far from my life. I don't see respect for personal space, which is very typical in relationships around me. On the other hand, in my relationship, there is a very typical personal space limitation. Without offending anyone, we can say that we are in a structure where we can even communicate and take breaks when we don't feel good.

Speaker 1 [00:04:37] Do you think these elements you mentioned at home increase the quality of your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:04:42] I think it increases as I think about it. Additionally, there is no expectation based on gender. In none of my relationships is there an expectation based on gender. Already, my partner does not use gender pronouns. In dynamics with other partners in my other relationships, there can sometimes be a gender-based agenda. But in the relationship we are currently discussing, there is no dynamic based on gender. That is, no one expects anything from anyone just because of their gender. Our expectations are entirely based on the characteristics of that person and their mood at that time, which I think increases the quality.

Speaker 1 [00:05:23] Can you give concrete examples of gender-based expectations?

Speaker 2 [00:05:29] For example, some people expect the male party to be more financially supportive and to meet needs. Sometimes, there are dynamics where the female party is expected to be more elegant, beautiful, organized, and energetic. I observe these dynamics around me. For instance, in another relationship, I found myself in a position where I usually received emotional support, sought help when upset, and relied on someone in times of trouble. In this relationship, I have no role based on anything. I am truly myself. Completely who I am.

Speaker 1 [00:06:04] Can I also ask how many romantic relationships you have had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:06:09] More than [6-10].

Speaker 1 [00:06:11] Okay, if you were to give a range?

Speaker 2 [00:06:16] I can say [6-10]. I think that would be a more accurate estimate.

Speaker 1 [00:06:21] Okay. How would you evaluate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:06:32] Well, I think it is more positive for many reasons that I have mentioned. But I also think the age factor plays a role. I am currently [20-25] years old, and in the relationships I have had until now, there were relationships that lasted for [1-5] and a half years and occupied a significant amount of time. I think the quality problem was due to a lack of experience and immaturity related to age. The fact that my current relationship is very disconnected from any traditional form also contributes to the quality being better.

Speaker 1 [00:07:21] You mentioned that it is more positive. You gave various reasons, but can you name other reasons that make it more positive compared to your past relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:07:40] One reason could be the fact that this is the first relationship I am having with someone of my own biological gender. This relationship is already distinct from all the others for me. The space given to me, allowing me to be more comfortable, and the lack of expectations based on any reason, along with the open communication, makes me feel more comfortable and at ease. This way, I can say that.

Speaker 1 [00:08:18] Alright. What makes a relationship high-quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:08:25] Respect for personal space. Spending time together. Feeling a connection to support each other. These are important. I think these two are what I can say. The term 'quality' feels a bit grandiose to me.

Speaker 1 [00:08:48] Unfortunately, in this research, we are trying to explore the concept of relationship quality, so we need to use this term. For instance, you mentioned the quality of the time spent together. What do you think differentiates the quality of the time spent together?

Speaker 2 [00:09:07] Let me put it this way, there have been times in another relationship where I felt bored during the time spent together. Normally, you could be doing something else, etc., but because I felt obliged to share something, give and take in a dialogue constantly, I got tired. In this relationship, just being in the same room, spending time together is a way of spending time for us. For instance, I like that my partner can focus on their own work while being happy with my presence. That's why we often study together. I can say that the most common activity we do is studying together. Then, when we make a plan to have wine together, I enjoy it. Sometimes, we do projects together, even though we are not in the same school or

department. We do projects through other organizations. We plan events together, create posters, and these are very different things for me.

Speaker 1 [00:10:22] What elements do you think make a relationship low-quality?

Speaker 2 [00:10:27] I think it's when communication styles are different. Let me give an example.

Speaker 1 [00:10:36] Please, continue.

Speaker 2 [00:10:37] Different communication styles, very different comfort zones might contribute. Also, having extremely different worldviews can make a relationship consortia (challenging). For example, if someone has a very different ideological stance and attitude towards life than I do, I cannot feel peaceful with them. Because at some point, I start feeling like this person argues with people who think like me on social media and thinks that most people who think like me are stupid. And I worry that if I reveal my intellectual side, they won't like me. So, I think having a similar worldview is important.

Speaker 1 [00:11:26] You mentioned different communication styles. Can you elaborate on that?

Speaker 2 [00:11:33] Sure. For example, this is because of a former partner who comes to mind. My ex-partner was someone who communicated only by making jokes in every situation. Normally, I like to communicate this way too, but not entirely through jokes. For example, you couldn't talk about something serious because their communication style avoided seriousness and tension, which was necessary in serious moments. Such things. Some people show their anger by staying silent. This is very terrifying for me because if I know the person in front of me is angry and stays silent, it means we can't resolve the problem, which makes me very panicked and feel bad.

Speaker 1 [00:12:29] In your answers, you mentioned respecting personal space. Can you provide more information about how one knows they are in a relationship where personal space is respected?

Speaker 2 [00:12:41] Of course, a love relationship where personal space is respected, how do we know it?

Speaker 1 [00:12:46] Yes, exactly.

Speaker 2 [00:12:47] For example, I had a very busy week. [6-10] days of the week were full with academic work. I was very busy with work and had one free day. On that one free day, let's say, I wanted to do something with my friends. If my partner says, "Why didn't you spend your only free day with me?" then it is a sign of disrespect for personal space. An ideal partner would say, "Okay, you worked all week and you get to decide how to spend your free day. I respect that." This shows that they prioritize my needs over their own. This is an excellent example of respect for personal space. Or, for example, we may want to share every problem we have or

learn about them, but if they insist on me sharing the details of something I'm sad about or don't insist when I say, "We'll talk later," it means they are respecting my personal space.

Speaker 1 [00:13:52] In your answers, you also mentioned comfort zones. What would you say about the times when a relationship lacks comfort zones? What are the times when you feel your comfort zone is most restricted in your relationship, for example?

Speaker 2 [00:14:12] It can be during a night out or when there are too many people around me who are unfamiliar to me. For example, the most uncomfortable time for me is when I spend time with my partner's other partner and they start arguing aggressively or passive-aggressively with each other. It feels like my parents are fighting right in front of me, and I feel panic. One is my friend and the other is my partner. If I support one, it can be misunderstood, and if I support the other, it can be even worse. So, I'm stuck in a grey area where two people I love are fighting in front of me, and I can't show my support or intervene. Generally, my comfort zone is shattered when there are other people around and a conflict is happening.

Speaker 1 [00:15:39] In such situations, do you feel that the quality of your relationship with your partner decreases?

Speaker 2 [00:15:47] Or I feel detached at a certain point. Or there was a situation where I should have been there, but I couldn't be there because I was afraid of the other person and couldn't express myself. I feel distant and think the quality drops when I'm unable to support my partner.

Speaker 1 [00:16:13] Of course, you can explain like that.

Speaker 2 [00:16:15] Sometimes, our mental states or my partner's mental state becomes so unfit for communication that it affects the quality. When our lives are intensely busy, and we have different physical distances and intensities, the time we can spend together drops, and when mental fatigue from life adds to this, I find myself unwilling to communicate. Naturally, at a certain point, even if my partner knows that my stress is due to life, they start to feel it personally and ask if there is a problem between us. The question "Is there a problem between us?" makes me feel more stressed because it brings up the issue of expectations from me, and I start to feel guilty, as if I haven't met some expectations.

Speaker 1 [00:17:16] So, what behaviors from your partner do you think could improve your relationship quality during these times when your mental state is unfit for communication?

Speaker 2 [00:17:32] Understanding helps my mental state a lot. If my partner says, "I understand that you are too stressed to communicate right now. Just tell me that there's no problem between us, and I'll leave you alone. You can call me when you need," this kind of support makes me very happy. But if they keep asking, "Did I do something? Is there a problem?" it makes me feel like I'm in a spiral of expectations, which usually triggers my mental issues related to failing to meet expectations, making it even worse.

Speaker 1 [00:18:11] So, can we say that one of the high-quality factors for you is the ability of partners to understand each other's situations and adjust their support expectations accordingly?

Speaker 2 [00:18:29] It sounds incredibly reasonable to me, but really accessible.

Speaker 1 [00:18:34] In your previous answers, you touched on some of these topics. However, since the main subject of the project is this, I'd like to ask again if it's okay with you. What are the most important things for you in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:18:52] Repeating my thoughts, it varies a bit over time, but fundamentally, being able to share life together is very important.

Speaker 1 [00:19:12] Can I ask why you said that?

Speaker 2 [00:19:15] Why do I say that?

Speaker 1 [00:19:17] Yes, why?

Speaker 2 [00:19:19] I think that the romantic connection can only continue up to a certain point if we are not on the same path or close paths in life. It can only spark for a short time and doesn't go towards romantic aspirations if the people are from very different backgrounds. It's true.

Speaker 1 [00:19:45] Of course.

Speaker 2 [00:19:47] That's my answer to this question.

Speaker 1 [00:19:49] Can you give concrete examples of sharing life together?

Speaker 2 [00:19:56] Of course. It can be like, after a long day at work or school, when we have no energy left to lift a finger, seeing that person and not feeling like we need to invest energy in communication. For instance, if there's an event, concert, or talk that I'm excited about, I want them to be there with me even if they're not particularly interested in the topic. It's important that they can say, "Okay, I'm fine, let's go together," and discuss it later. For example, not having a critical outlook or judgmental attitude is necessary. One example: there was an event at my [location] where feminist organizations gathered, introduced themselves, and there were talks and documentary screenings. I didn't want to go alone. I invited two of my partners, saying, "Please come, let's be there together." I didn't invite the other person because I couldn't imagine them fitting into that environment. It's essential that they can say, "Sure, I'll come," even if they don't have a strong interest. This willingness to accompany each other, especially in shared living spaces, enhances relationship quality.

Speaker 1 [00:22:07] Do you think such situations increase your relationship quality?

Speaker 2 [00:22:10] Yes, definitely. Because someone who stands at the center of my life, sharing the same struggles with me, makes me feel understood and close, both mentally and emotionally. This brings us closer together.

Speaker 1 [00:22:27] I understand. What does love mean to you?

Speaker 2 [00:22:33] I've thought a lot about this recently. It's a state of elevation when we remember someone we love (sevgi). It's more than just a routine relationship; it's knowing that even if this person leaves my life, I will continue to remember them with deep respect and affection. It's a relationship where you feel you would always cherish them even if they're no longer around.

Speaker 1 [00:23:15] Hmm, can you elaborate on the idea of "cherishing them even if they're no longer around"? Or give concrete examples?

Speaker 2 [00:23:44] Of course. For instance, I had someone I was seeing in [Location]. Even though we no longer have any contact, I think of them with a smile. They were the first person I truly fell in love (aşk) with. Even though they are no longer part of my life, thinking of them brings a smile to my face. They represent so much for me. It's like there's nothing that compels me to remember them, but I do, and I smile, feeling a sense of respect and gratitude. It allows me to continue more happily.

Speaker 1 [00:24:36] How important do you think love (aşk) is in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:24:42] I think it's crucial for continuity. It plays a critical role in enhancing the ability of individuals to tolerate each other, which in turn prolongs the lifespan of romantic relationships.

Speaker 1 [00:25:05] Yes, I heard you. Please continue.

Speaker 2 [00:25:06] I can continue without further questions.

Speaker 1 [00:25:08] Please do.

Speaker 2 [00:25:12] In difficult times, we often find the behavior of a loved one intolerable if there is no deep love (aşk) involved. When the spark and intense feelings exist, it enhances our ability to tolerate and overlook annoying behaviors. Love (aşk) helps increase the lifespan of romantic relationships by boosting our tolerance levels.

Speaker 1 [00:25:49] How do you understand that your partner loves (sever) you? How do you realize that you love (sevgili) your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:25:58] How do I know? Let me think about that. I understand it when my partner does things like thinking of me at random times, sharing something special with me unexpectedly, or making an effort to show affection even in a crowded setting. For example, if they are busy with something, yet they take a moment to smile at me, it shows their love (sevgi).

Speaker 1 [00:26:46] How do these behaviors of showing love (sevgi) and being busy while making you feel loved (sevgi) manifest concretely for you? How does showing patience and respect look like?

Speaker 2 [00:27:02] I've already given concrete examples in my mind. For instance, during a conference, my partner was doing a presentation. It was a serious environment with their mother, aunt, my friends, and other people who we had to be relatively formal with. While presenting, if they felt nervous or stumbled, they would look at me and feel a bit reassured. Although I was focused, the fact that they could take 15 seconds to smile at me amidst all that, knowing that our connection is special, made me feel loved (sevgi).

Speaker 1 [00:28:02] What difficulties do you face in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:28:07] Difficulties? I definitely think there's a time problem. Both of us have an issue with making time for each other. We manage by studying together or finding shared activities. It's not anyone's fault, but it's a problem. We also have issues with communication lapses due to our busy schedules. Additionally, we both have similar psychiatric issues and medications. Our mental problems sometimes coincide, which can be frustrating. We have communication barriers because of our mental states. So, I think the time problem is significant.

Speaker 1 [00:29:02] How do you think this time problem affects the quality of your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:29:09] It has a negative effect, but not a huge one.

Speaker 1 [00:29:12] Hmm. Would it be better if you had more time together?

Speaker 2 [00:29:17] Spending more time together would be better.

Speaker 1 [00:29:21] Yes, it could be. Do you argue with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:29:36] Yes, of course.

Speaker 1 [00:29:40] I'm sorry, I think it cut off.

Speaker 2 [00:29:46] It's reconnecting.

Speaker 1 [00:29:50] Okay. Do you argue with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:29:54] No, never.

Speaker 1 [00:29:55] Do you have disagreements?

Speaker 2 [00:30:00] Yes, of course.

Speaker 1 [00:30:01] How often do you have these disagreements?

Speaker 2 [00:30:08] Every two months or so.

Speaker 1 [00:30:11] What are these disagreements usually about?

Speaker 2 [00:30:16] They are about how one should behave or things like "You did this wrong." For example, one might say, "You were wrong in this matter, and it hurt me." Things like that.

Speaker 1 [00:30:39] Are there specific topics or expression styles that are recurring sources of disagreement, such as work or miscommunication?

Speaker 2 [00:31:00] There's one recurring issue. I get very anxious about serious conversations due to past traumas, so if a conversation becomes serious, I sometimes avoid communication. For example, if there's a situation where I foresee criticism, I might avoid the conversation entirely, which becomes a recurring issue.

Speaker 1 [00:31:44] How do you resolve these disagreements?

Speaker 2 [00:31:49] Generally, through mutual understanding and patience. My partner usually approaches me with understanding, saying, "I get why you did that, but..." I need to break out of my shell and be more open to criticism, realizing that my partner is not angry but trying to solve the problem.

Speaker 1 [00:32:18] What other ways do you think are important for maintaining the relationship besides patience and understanding?

Speaker 2 [00:32:48] Respecting personal space, supporting each other, and being supportive in the steps each person wants to take in life are very important. Not discouraging each other, not being derogatory, and being supportive no matter what the topic is.

Speaker 1 [00:33:33] Do you think this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:33:37] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:33:38] Why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:33:41] Because it is the most comfortable human relationship experience I've had in my life. No matter what state I'm in or what I've done, the first person I want to tell is my partner. When I'm happy, the first person I want to share it with is my partner. Even if I think what I'm feeling is meaningless and I'm uncomfortable with myself, the person I can tell without feeling judged is my partner. This is why.

Speaker 1 [00:34:13] Can you give concrete examples of not feeling judged, feeling comfortable sharing anything with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:34:19] Sure. For example, when I feel really bad and tell them that I feel like hurting myself, they are the only person who can help me properly. If I tell someone else, they

might try to convince me that it's not that bad or suggest seeing a specialist instead of listening. But my partner understands exactly how I feel and knows how to help me correctly.

Speaker 1 [00:35:02] Has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2 [00:35:05] Yes, definitely.

Speaker 1 [00:35:08] In what way?

Speaker 2 [00:35:10] Their life perspective has partly influenced me. They have made me aware of some issues that I wasn't previously sensitive to. Also, being in a non-monogamous relationship has led me to rethink traditional views on relationships. My perspective on relationships has almost entirely changed. The qualities I look for in a partner have changed. I've realized some things I did wrong in past relationships that caused harm. I've learned that things don't always need to be done in the traditional way. In cultural terms, we share many common values, which has enriched me greatly.

Speaker 1 [00:36:11] You mentioned that your perspective on relationships has changed. In what way has it changed?

Speaker 2 [00:36:19] Previously, I held onto certain norms very tightly. I've learned that I don't have to live by these norms. I've realized that some solutions to interpersonal issues aren't as difficult as I thought. To give a concrete example, my previous relationships followed a routine where I would be with a man, then break up, get bored, and move on to another man, repeating the same cycle. Now, in a queer and open relationship, I understand that relationships can offer many benefits beyond this cycle. They can be something that doesn't drain energy but instead elevates it. I've realized it's possible to have a respectful relationship where traditional norms are not necessary.

Speaker 1 [00:37:36] Can you elaborate on the benefits you mentioned? What kind of benefits are you talking about?

Speaker 2 [00:37:42] The benefits are in fundamental human communication. When something happens, knowing that there is someone who understands you and provides supportive feedback greatly benefits my life. Instead of isolating myself and falling into a deeper mental spiral, I can talk to someone who truly cares about me. This fundamental human interaction is very valuable to me.

Speaker 1 [00:38:27] Yes. You also mentioned realizing mistakes in past relationships. What kind of mistakes did you realize?

Speaker 2 [00:38:36] For example, I realized that I intervened too much in others' personal spaces while expecting my own space to be respected. I noticed that my jealousy often stemmed from insecurity. I learned that the way to handle jealousy in a romantic relationship is not through control but by establishing trust and finding the source of insecurity. This realization significantly reduced my anxiety levels.

Speaker 1 [00:39:25] Lastly, you mentioned that the qualities you look for in a partner have changed. What kind of qualities have changed? For instance, what did you look for before and what do you look for now?

Speaker 2 [00:39:41] Previously, I looked for similarities in artistic and academic fields, but I realized that these alone are not enough for a relationship. Now, I look for alignment in political attitudes towards life. I seek someone who respects and understands the values I hold dear. I no longer tolerate people who dismiss open relationships or queer culture. I need my partner to be aware and supportive of these aspects of my life. So, political alignment and respect for shared values have become crucial for me.

Speaker 1 [00:42:19] I understand. Has your partner changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:42:26] I don't think they've changed much. In simple matters, I've noticed changes, but I can't speak for their own interpretation. For instance, I felt that my presence allowed them to think independently from their other partner. They began to incorporate more emotional elements into their interactions, realizing that adding emotions doesn't necessarily harm the relationship. I also believe they became less dependent on their other partner, making more independent decisions and recognizing the importance of emotional connections.

Speaker 1 [00:44:22] You emphasized the importance of romantic elements. What do you think makes a relationship romantic?

Speaker 2 [00:44:32] I think what makes a relationship romantic is the extent to which emotions drive actions. For example, if I'm upset with my partner, I should be able to say, "I did this because I love you (aşk) and couldn't control my emotions." If everything is rationalized and always placed on a logical basis, I think it lacks romance. In romantic relationships, not everything is expected to be rational.

Speaker 1 [00:45:33] Do you feel secure in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:45:36] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:45:37] Why do you say that?

Speaker 2 [00:45:40] Because nothing about my existence or personality feels threatened. There is no unjust criticism, and my goals and ambitions are fully supported. These things make me feel secure.

Speaker 1 [00:46:04] Now, I will share a screen with you. If I ask, "My partner generally really listens to me," how would you rate this on a scale of 1 to 9, where 1 is not true at all and 9 is completely true?

Speaker 2 [00:46:22] I would give it an 8.

Speaker 1 [00:46:27] Okay. How about "My partner is generally responsive to my needs," on the same scale?

Speaker 2 [00:46:37] I would give it a 7. Because their intention is there.

Speaker 1 [00:46:46] For the first statement, "My partner generally really listens to me," you gave an 8. Why did you give that answer?

Speaker 2 [00:46:54] I want to explain why I didn't give a full score. Rarely, my partner focuses too much on their own perspective in the issue I'm explaining, instead of the part I am upset about. Other than that, I know they listen to me with their full attention.

Speaker 1 [00:47:17] Can you give concrete examples of when this happens?

Speaker 2 [00:47:24] For example, if I had a problem at school, let's say a social issue, and I explain it. My partner might focus too much on a different aspect of the problem, like someone twisting my words, while I was actually upset about being insulted. They tend to focus on protecting me from someone's ill intentions rather than addressing the insult itself.

Speaker 1 [00:48:00] Why did you give an 8 instead of a 7 or a 9?

Speaker 2 [00:48:14] Because I know their full effort is to listen to me. I didn't give a 9 because it's not perfect; sometimes their mind gets stuck on different points. But I didn't give a 7 either because I know their genuine effort is to listen to me.

Speaker 1 [00:48:31] For the second statement, "My partner is generally responsive to my needs," you gave a 7. Why did you give that answer?

Speaker 2 [00:48:41] Here, I think no human can be fully responsive to another's needs at all times. Also, my needs change frequently, and I have a sensitive nature, so it's already challenging to be responsive to my needs consistently. This makes it hard for anyone, not just my partner, to follow and meet my needs accurately.

Speaker 1 [00:49:21] Hmm. Can you give concrete examples of when you feel your partner hasn't been able to follow your needs?

Speaker 2 [00:49:32] For example, if I cancel plans because I'm feeling unwell, sometimes my partner doesn't fully grasp how physically unwell I am, and I have to repeatedly emphasize it. Instances like these where they don't fully get my distress make me feel misunderstood.

Speaker 1 [00:50:07] Why did you give a 7 instead of a 6 or an 8?

Speaker 2 [00:50:14] Because 6 felt too low, and 8 seemed too high. So 7 seemed just right, given the circumstances.

Speaker 1 [00:50:31] Okay. If you don't mind, before we finish, we'd like to learn more about physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker 2 [00:50:49] It hasn't happened for a long time.

Speaker 1 [00:50:52] Hmm. How satisfied are you with your sexual life?

Speaker 2 [00:50:58] I am satisfied, but neither of us is happy with the infrequency. However, I am content with the experience when it happens.

Speaker 1 [00:51:08] Can you elaborate on why you said that?

Speaker 2 [00:51:12] Because, how can I say, the experience itself is very good, but I don't feel the need for it as often as I did in other relationships. This relationship involves less sexuality, but I don't know why. When it does happen, it makes me happy, but I don't seek it as much in this relationship compared to others.

Speaker 1 [00:51:48] Do you think the lack of sexual activity affects the quality of your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:51:56] From my perspective, there's no problem, but I've noticed it upsets my partner.

Speaker 1 [00:52:03] Do you think sex is important in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:52:07] I think it is important in most relationships but not in all.

Speaker 1 [00:52:12] How important is it to you?

Speaker 2 [00:52:16] I think it depends a lot on the dynamic of the relationship. It can vary, but it might constitute about 50 to 60 percent of the relationship's importance in many cases.

Speaker 1 [00:52:30] Why do you say that?

Speaker 2 [00:52:38] Because physical closeness generally provides an additional emotional bond.

Speaker 1 [00:52:47] I will share another screen with you. Overall, how satisfied are you with your relationship? On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is not satisfied at all and 10 is completely satisfied, what would you choose?

Speaker 2 [00:53:06] I am very satisfied. I would choose 8.

Speaker 1 [00:53:15] How would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship quality? On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 is not satisfied at all and 10 is completely satisfied, what would you choose?

Speaker 2 [00:53:26] I would say between 7 and 8.

Speaker 1 [00:53:29] Which one would you choose?

Speaker 2 [00:53:32] I would choose 7.

Speaker 1 [00:53:34] Why did you give a 7?

Speaker 2 [00:53:44] Because it felt like a 7.

Speaker 1 [00:53:50] Can you explain the factors behind giving a 7?

Speaker 2 [00:53:57] There are different factors. I'm trying to be explanatory, but I feel like I keep saying the same things, which is tiring me out.

Speaker 1 [00:54:06] Please continue.

Speaker 2 [00:54:07] Like I said, sometimes we could understand each other better. It's really hard to keep things clear because we are both so busy. Given all these complications, 7 seems right.

Speaker 1 [00:54:35] Why didn't you choose 6 or 8?

Speaker 2 [00:54:44] Because 6 felt too low. I could have given an 8, but I felt more towards a 7. Maybe a weakening bond due to communication issues led me to give a 7.

Speaker 1 [00:55:06] Okay. Do you think your relationship met your expectations?

Speaker 2 [00:55:27] Yes, it did in many ways.

Speaker 1 [00:55:30] Can you explain which ways it met your expectations?

Speaker 2 [00:55:39] Sure. Feeling understood, having intense feelings, feeling supported, and having my needs met are some ways it met my expectations.

Speaker 1 [00:55:56] Do you think there are any expectations that were not met?

Speaker 2 [00:56:01] No, I don't think so.

Speaker 1 [00:56:04] Alright. We are about to finish, but I want to summarize what we discussed in this interview to ensure accuracy and see if there is anything you'd like to add. We started with demographic questions. You mentioned you are [20-25] years old and have been with your partner for [6-10] months. You live with your [name] and are a [occupation]. [Portion Redacted] Comparing the quality of your relationship with others, you mentioned it's non-traditional, has less cliché problems, and provides more inner peace and honesty. You said it's more positive than past relationships due to maturity and open communication. High-quality factors for you include respect for personal space, quality time together, creating things together, having comfort zones, and having the same communication style. You also discussed your understanding of love (sevgi), emphasizing emotional connection, and said love (aşk) is crucial for continuity in relationships. Your partner shows love (sevgi) through unexpected gestures and attention. You noted time and communication as the main difficulties in your

relationship, resolving disagreements with patience and understanding. You said the relationship is good for you, being the most comfortable human relationship you've experienced, and shared examples of support and non-judgment. The relationship has positively changed you, making you more aware of certain issues, and your perspective on relationships has evolved. You mentioned that your partner has also changed, becoming less dependent on their other partner. You feel secure in the relationship, and your partner generally listens to you and is responsive to your needs, though you rated these aspects as 8 and 7, respectively. You discussed the importance of physical intimacy, rating your relationship satisfaction as 7. Lastly, you said the relationship met your expectations, particularly in feeling understood and supported. Do you have anything to add to this summary?

Speaker 2 [01:01:09] The first option felt more reasonable to me. I honestly think that the number of distinguishing details in the story is quite high.

Speaker 1 [01:01:50] Thank you so much for participating in this study. This research is also being conducted in Brazil, the Netherlands, France, and the United States. Your perspective is invaluable to us. For the study to succeed, if it's okay with you, we have one more request. Could you suggest two close people in your life as candidates for this study? We will ask them to recommend other couples who you don't know or interact with. This way, we aim to reach as diverse a group of participants as possible. Is this suitable for you?

Speaker 2 [01:01:50] I'm not sure if I can find anyone, but I'll think about it.

Speaker 1 [01:01:55] Alright. Also, after this interview, I will send you a survey. It will take about 10 minutes at most. Please complete it using your participant code. Your responses will remain anonymous. Thank you again for your participation. It was really valuable for us. Good luck with everything.

Speaker 2 [01:02:24] You're welcome. Thank you as well. Good luck with your research.

Speaker 1 [01:02:29] Thank you very much. Goodbye.

Speaker 2 [01:02:32] Goodbye.